



SCARCE THE TENTH PERSON OF ANY SORT WAS LEFT ALIVE

THE OUTBREAK OF THE BLACK DEATH IN EUROPE (1347)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The Black Death

BEFORE

1315–1319 Famines strike western Europe: 15 percent of Dutch city-dwellers die.

1316 Edward II of England fixes staple food prices as shortages drive them upward.

Late 1330s Bubonic plague spreads gradually westward from western China.

AFTER

1349 Accused of starting the plague, Jews are murdered in the thousands in Germany.

1349 Pope bans the flagellant “Brothers of the Cross.”

1351 Statute of Labourers is passed in England.

1381 Peasants’ Revolt stirs political rebellion across large parts of England.

1424 Dance of Death painted on the cloister walls of the Cimetière des Innocents, Paris.

In late November 1347, a galley entered the Italian port of Genoa, having fled a Tatar siege of Kaffa in the Crimea. It bore a deadly cargo: the bubonic plague. Within a mere two years this lethal pestilence had killed more than a third of the population of Europe and the Middle East, and altered the regions’ economic, social, and religious makeup forever.

Spread of the Black Death

Having probably originated in Central Asia or western China in the 1330s, the plague’s initial progress westward was slow, but after it reached Crimea and Constantinople in 1347 it spread rapidly along maritime trade routes. Having hit Genoa, it appeared quickly in Sicily and Marseilles; by 1348 it had struck Spain, Portugal, and England, and it reached Germany and Scandinavia by 1349.

The epidemic’s main vector was infected fleas and the rats that harbored them, both of which flourished in the unsanitary conditions of the time. The main symptoms of the disease were swellings, known as buboes, that appeared in the groin, neck, or armpits. These were followed by black blotches on the skin (hence “Black Death”) and then, in around three-quarters of cases, by death.

Contemporaries ascribed the causes of the pestilence variously to divine punishment for immorality, adverse conjunctions of the planets, earthquakes, or bad vapors. There was no cure, but preventive advice included abstinence from hard-to-digest food, the use of aromatic herbs to purify the air, and—the only effective measure—avoiding the company of others.